

To begin with, it would be better to clear out the confusion about what constitutes a robot versus a mechanical machine. While according to some definitions early computing machines, as well as mechanical clocks, would technically be robots, what we are looking at here are humanoid machines - machines that mimic, or excel, humans in purpose and shape. A factory in Dongguan, China - the one belonging to Changying Precision Technology - replaced 90 per cent of its 600-strong human workforce with robots - and soon saw a 250 per cent rise in productivity and a 20 per cent drop in defects. Last year, Foxconn replaced 60,000 of its workers in one iPhone factory with robots and announced that it aims for 30 per cent automation at its Chinese factories by 2020. While your nightmares from Westworld are going to stay that way for a good while, it is undeniable that we have arrived at an age where robots taking our jobs is no longer the stuff of conjecture. From the ancient automatons of lore to the modern-day mechanoids - they've evolved faster than humans, and it would be better to know about their history before they erase ours, or NOT! (Just saying!).

Historic Robots

In various cultures, some artificial creations have always been brought into their world by beings of mythical powers - clay golems, Talos from Greek mythology and more. Some of the earliest stories (since there's barely any physical evidence to credibility) and concepts date back to as far as the 4th century BC when Greek Mathematician Archytas of Tarentum proposed the design of a steam-propelled bird. Across the world, starting from Indian history to the European myths, robots have been mentioned and conceptualised throughout history - along with tales of them protecting or attacking, mankind. But one of the first documented designs of a humanoid robot came much later in Da Vinci's notebooks from the year 1495. The designs, most likely based on his anatomical research for the Vitruvian man, were intricate and detailed a mechanical knight that could sit up, wave its arms and move its head and jaw.

The 18th century saw a lot of activity in the field of robotics. Automata in this century - mostly as toys or means of entertainment for the rich - were actually capable of acting, drawing, flying and even playing music. Jacques de Vaucanson, who designed and constructed multiple iconic automatons of Talos represented on an ancient coin in that era, was a robotics pioneer of this time. In 1737, Vaucanson built the Flute